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Susan Cooper's ^{born 1935} well known "Dark is Rising" stories are an epic fantasy drawing heavily on Celtic and Anglo-Saxon legend to provide weaponry for the good and evil sides in opposition throughout the novels. Her backgrounds are equally the stuff of legend: Cornwall, North Wales and the Cilterns, but also outside time on a lost island, and in the interior of the Welsh mountain.

There are five novels in the series all concerned with the ultimate battle between good and evil, the Light and the Dark, in which immortal Old Ones and Dark Lords as well as mortals play their part.

Over Sea, Under Stone, the first of these, deals with the search for the grail by three children, Simon, Jane and Barney Drew, on holiday in Cornwall with their adoptive uncle Merriman Lyon (Merlin).

The Arthurian overtones are plain, with the three pursuing their quest by means of an ancient map, opposed by creatures of the dark who desire the grail for their own ends.

In The Dark is Rising, Merriman Lyon appears once more this time in Buckinghamshire as teacher and Old One, tutoring Will Stanton, the seventh son of a seventh son, who wakes on his eleventh birthday to discover he, too, is one of the immortals on the side of the light.

As he seeks the six signs which will defeat the Dark when it rises at the turn of the year, he learns his powers and their part in the long-fought war, where magic is bound by strict rules except for the Wild Magic, which stands beyond any constraint.

The search for the weapons of the Light—a harp, six sleepers, and the raven boy—continues in Greenwitch and The Grey King, where Cooper expands the

complexities of Wild Magic and the difficulty of relations between mortals and immortals.

The Greenwitch, an offering made to Tethys, the sea, by the women and girls of Trewissick in the same Cornish setting as *Over Sea, Under Stone*, holds a secret desired by both Light and Dark. Jane Drew, who helped in its making, is instrumental in winning this secret for the Light, proving that mortals play a role in the war.

Conversely, in *The Grey King*, it is human emotions which are the danger--jealousy, anger and hate, which open minds to the invasion of the Dark. The fourth book is strongly Arthurian in content.

Will Stanton is sent to the mountains in North Wales to continue his work for the Light; here he meets Bran, the raven boy, unknown to himself the son of Arthur Pendragon, brought forward in time by Guinevere with Merriman's assistance, and whose coming triggers a sequence of events that prove nearly fatal to the Light.

Silver On the Tree is the culmination of the conflict, where humans as well as Old ones play a decisive part in the final battle. The three Drew children, Will, Merriman and Bran are involved in the quest for the crystal sword with which the Dark will be defeated, Wild and Old Magic driving away the Dark which has entered the hearts of humankind.

Cooper's scholarly knowledge of legend, and skill in drawing together all the complexities of the five books into a triumphant finale, produce an epic of great power.

Cooper deals with the innate antagonism between mortals and impressively, and in the *The Grey King* reaches great heights as she mingles worlds and people of

legend and the present day. The sequence of books are a remarkable achievement, and Cooper's gift for description and characterization provide additional pleasure to novels replete with intellectual enjoyment.

Cooper's books are intensely satisfying for readers of all ages. She succeeds in producing the most desirable aspect of books for children--the subversive element where children are more aware of the subtext than adults--while discussing issues of extreme complexity.

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SUSAN COOPER ON HER *DARK IS RISING* SERIES:

Because Susan has written a great deal about her series, I want to extensively quote her concerning her views about it.

She says: "I suppose there are plenty of reasons why I should have spent a large chunk of my life writing the five fantasy novels of the Dark is Rising series, dealing with the struggle for control of the earth between the forces of good and evil, the Light and the Dark.

Fantasy is founded on myth and one of the great themes of myth is the conflict between good and evil. And I was soaked in fairy tale and myth and folklore from the age of about three.

Then there's religion. I was raised in the Church of England, drenched in liturgical music and marinated in the King James Bible, not to mention *Paradise Lost*, later on. And even tho I turned away from Christianity when I was sixteen, yhou don't get rid of God and the Devil as easily as that. Their images lurk in your unconscious forever, like a watermark in paper.

She nevertheless believes the deepest roots of her books were embedded in war, mainly WW II. She goes on to say:

"That cold white flame at the heart of the Light, and Will's justification of it, comes from the absolute certainty I was given, when I was small, that *we were right*. Hitler was evil, and the greedy advance of the third Reich across Europe was the rising of the Dark.

"Little Britain, Jack the Giant-killer, was the last repository of the Light, and anything we did to defeat the Dark was okay. Even our churches confirmed this: One should pray for victory, said the archbishop of Canterbury, adding to the prayer "if it be thy will" or "for the victory of righteousness"

She points out the danger of both the light and the dark saying:

"The self-rightousness of the Light is no doubt preferable to the depravity of the dark, but it too holds great dangers. It can reach to the point of a holy war, fought for the promotion of one of the historically militant religions, like Christianity or Islam--and at that point, the Light enters the Dark, or vice versa, and gives birth to monstrosities like the Inquisition, or the death sentence pronounced on Salman Rushdie. . . .(and I would add, the terrorism we have just witnessed).

She goes on to point out that hers is not a Christian viewpoint in the line of C.S. Lewis's Narnia books. In fact, The Church of Scotland's board of Social responsibility accused them of undermining the Christian faith (21 years after publication).

She admits that you won't find a theistic ideal infusing those books. Instead, there is the echo of the author, the wartime child and postwar adolescent, observing conflict and imperfection. ("Swords and Ploughshares" essays on writing for children)

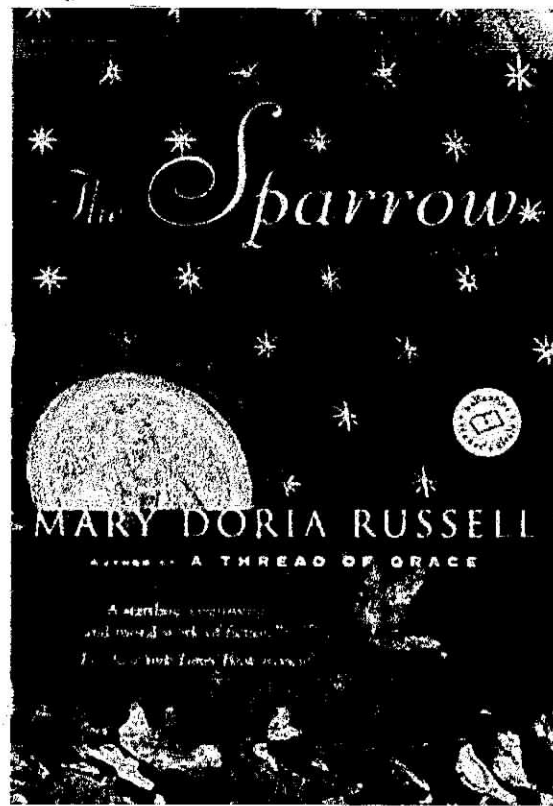
She comments that in the book Silver on the Tree she had to move away from the Arthurian legend because it seems that the Arthurian legend was parallel to the Christian story of the leader who dies for salvation.

She said: "What my books were trying to say is that nobody else can save us. We have to save ourselves. Silver on the Tree contains a reference to a poem that I remember my mother reciting to me. It's about Drake being in his hammock, which recalls the local legend in Devon that Sir Francis Drake will come back to rescue England if we're ever invaded again.

Similarly, Arthur will come back, and Christ--they are saviours. I didn't want to use that idea. The Arthur that I was using goes to Avalon, but saving the world is up to the people in it."

1996 The Sparrow by Mary Doria Russell (1950) 5

The Sparrow and Children of God caused a sensation when they first came out, and I remember reading both of them in a rush, completely taken with the way Mary Doria Russell took Emilio Sandoz' religious faith as seriously as his linguistic studies. And I would still say this aspect of the book holds up—Emilio's belief in God is fierce and unshakable, it just shifts from love and



obedience, before Rakhat, to bitterness and resentment afterwards. Since he comes to believe that he and his friends have been used as tools, it forces him to look at the idea of "God having a plan" in a whole new way. That idea can be comforting, but when the God that you've dedicated your life to returns your love by treating you like a UPS package (not even the guy driving the truck—the package), it can kind of mess you up.

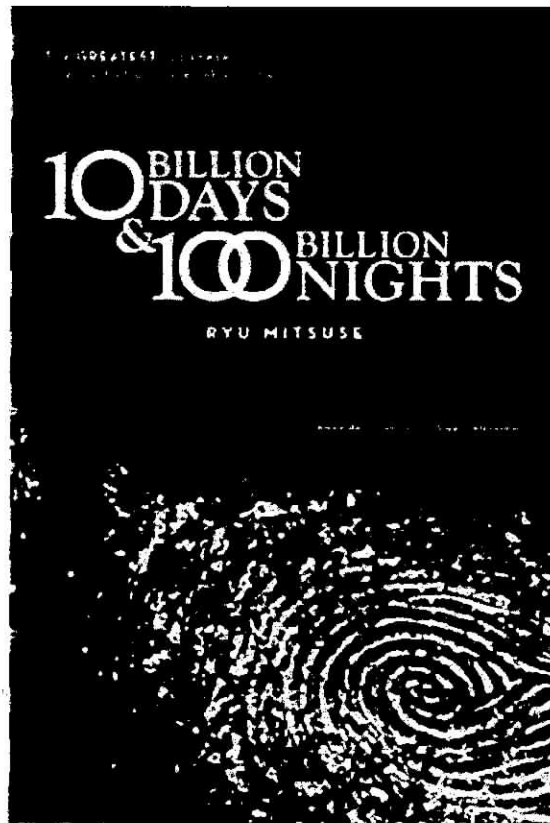
Both books look unflinchingly at Emilio's feeling of betrayal, but they also explore the idea that the long game he's caught up in is more important than any of the people getting hurt. Russell is also careful to balance Emilio's fervent beliefs with those of Sofia Medes, whose dedication to Judaism is treated just as respectfully as Emilio's Catholicism. One of the highlights of the first book is their ongoing theological conversation, as she challenges him to explain his rituals and compares them to her own.

2011

Ryu Mitsuse's Ten Billion Days and One Hundred Billion

Nights is an interesting take on religion (though not always a positive one) and mashes up figures from several different faiths into one time-spanning adventure. Written in 1967, and then revised and republished in 1973, the book has recently come out from Haikasoru and found a Western audience. Plato spends ten billion days

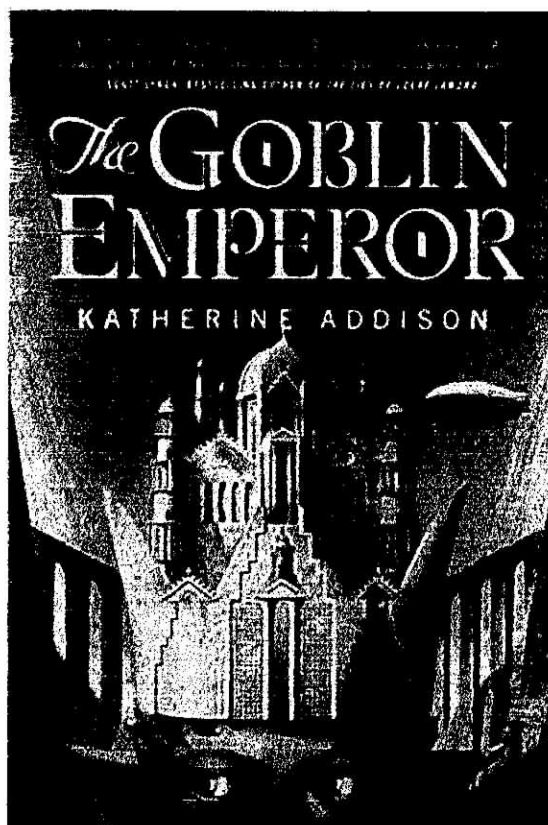
studying "the true systems of the world" while Jesus, Siddhartha, and the demigod Asura spend One Hundred Billion Nights traveling to the future to witness the heat death of the universe. Now, this is where things get more interesting: "Asura" is usually a catch-all term referring to a group of demigods or demons in Hinduism, but here they're personified by a single young girl. Plus, Jesus is a cyborg assassin? And he and Asura are fighting over the fate of life in the universe? The book can be read as a conversation between Christianity, Buddhism, and Hinduism, with some Greek philosophy thrown in for good measure... or just as a picaresque that is by turns wacky and unsettling, as the characters hurtle toward the end of all life in the universe.



2014 The Goblin Emperor by Katherine Addison -

The Goblin Emperor was one
~~of my favorite books of 2014.~~
 came out in

The main character, Maia, is a sweet, loving, but painfully shy young man who has grown up in exile as the fourth, unwanted half-goblin son of a powerful Elven emperor. When his father and three elder brothers die in an accident, Maia has to ascend to the throne, despite his lack of training or support. Maia has to fight his court on



many fronts to prove his fitness to rule, but one of the most interesting challenges is religious. Officially, the Elven court worships several gods and goddesses, has regular religious services, and holds formal weddings, coronations, and funerals that all involve religious elements. They also employ people known as Witnesses for the Dead, who commune with those who have died by accident or foul play in order to determine justice. However, this religiosity seems to be mere lip service for most of the court, and there are references to fashionable skepticism when it comes to the gods. Maia, who spent the first few years of his life with his loving, mystically-minded mother, has a very different approach to faith. Not only does he sincerely believe in the goddesses he worships, but he also associates his beliefs with the

only happy time in his life.

Plus, if he's going to follow his religion properly, he needs to meditate, which requires solitude...which is the one thing, as Emperor, he'll never have again. He has to find ways to assert his right to his religion, while also making sure his secular courtiers don't think he's a fanatic. This plotline is submerged fairly deeply in the novel, but hinted at throughout, and gradually becomes more important as Maia finds his footing as a ruler. Addison handles it delicately, showing the reader how Maia expresses his faith through his actions rather than trying to explain theological rules.

~~The Time Quintet by Madeleine L'Engle~~

her day.

Not only is Lizzie's faith, and lack thereof, treated respectfully throughout this book, but also her role as a vicar becomes central to the plot in the sequel, *The Lost Child of Lychford*, where her Christmas obligations become entangled with her magical practice in a terrifying way.

Alif the Unseen by G. Willow Wilson - pub 2012

Alif the Unseen takes a similar tack, including faithful Muslims and a respectful treatment of Islam alongside a more magical tale of a group of djinn. Alif's long-gone father is Muslim, but his mother was Hindu, so he lives in the margins of his primarily Muslim city. He helps both pornographers and revolutionaries online, staying just ahead of state censors... most of the time.



But when he's given a mysterious text called the *Alf Yeom*—which is the “1001 Days,” an inversion of the 1001 Nights—he finds himself in a much larger battle with the apparatus behind the state, a battle that he's only

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going to win with a little help from his djinn.

The novel features a range of approaches to Islam, including an imam who was also imprisoned by the state, who describes his faith:

I have had much experience with the unclean and uncivilized in the recent past. Shall I tell you what I discovered? I am not the state of my feet. I am not the dirt on my hands or the hygiene of my private parts. If I were these things, I would not have been at liberty to pray. . . . But I did pray, because I am not these things. . . I am not even myself. I am a string of bones speaking the word God.

While the book's plot is more concerned with Alif's work as a hacker, the book returns to questions of religion repeatedly, to explore Islam as a faith and as an identity.

~~The Sparrow and Children of God by Mary Doria Russell~~

10
For other uses, see His Dark Materials (disambiguation).

His Dark Materials is an epic trilogy of fantasy novels by Philip Pullman consisting of *Northern Lights* (1995) (published as *The Golden Compass* in North America), *The Subtle Knife* (1997), and *The Amber Spyglass* (2000). It follows the coming of age of two children, Lyra Belacqua and Will Parry, as they wander through a series of parallel universes. The novels have won a number of awards, including the Carnegie Medal in 1995 for *Northern Lights* and the 2001 Whitbread Book of the Year for *The Amber Spyglass*.

His Dark Materials has been marketed to young adults, though Pullman wrote with no target audience in mind. The fantasy elements include witches and armoured polar bears; the trilogy also alludes to concepts from physics, philosophy and theology. It functions in part as a retelling and inversion of John Milton's epic *Paradise Lost*,^[1] with Pullman commending humanity for what Milton saw as its most tragic failing, original sin.^[2] The series has attracted controversy for its criticism of religion.

The London Royal National Theatre staged a two-part adaptation of the series in 2003–2004. New Line Cinema released a film adaptation of *Northern Lights*, *The Golden Compass*, in 2007. Pullman followed the trilogy with two shorter books set in the same universe, *Lyra's Oxford* (2003) and *Once Upon a Time in the North* (2008). *La Belle Sauvage*, the first book in a new trilogy, *The Book of Dust*, was published on 19 October 2017.

Settings

Main article: Locations in His Dark Materials

The trilogy takes place across a multiverse, moving between many parallel worlds. In *Northern Lights*, the story takes place in a world with some similarities to our own; dress-style resembles that of the UK's Victorian era, and technology has not evolved to include automobiles or fixed-wing aircraft, while zeppelins feature as a notable mode of transport.

The dominant religion has parallels with Christianity,^[3] and is at certain points in the series

(especially in the later books) explicitly named so; while Adam and Eve are referenced in the text (particularly in *The Subtle Knife*, in which Dust tells Mary Malone that Lyra Belacqua is a new Eve to whom she is to be the serpent), Jesus is not.^[4] The Church (called the "Magisterium", the same name as the authority of the Catholic Church) exerts a strong control over society and has some of the appearance and organisation of the Catholic Church, but one in which the centre of power had moved from Rome to Geneva, moved there by Pullman's fictional "Pope John Calvin" (Geneva was the home of the historical John Calvin).^[5]

In *The Subtle Knife*, the story moves between the world of the first novel, our own world, and in another world, the city of Cittàgazze. In *The Amber Spyglass* the story crosses through an array of diverse worlds.

Titles

His Dark Materials



Cover of Scholastic collected edition, 2008.

Northern Lights

The Subtle Knife

The Amber Spyglass

Author	Philip Pullman
Country	United Kingdom
Language	English
Genre	Science fantasy High fantasy
Publisher	Scholastic
Published	1995–2000
Media type	Print (hardback & paperback)



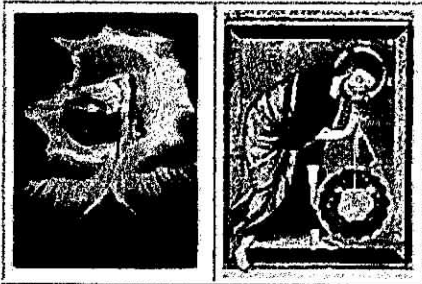
Satan struggles through hell in a Gustave Doré illustration of *Paradise Lost*.

The title of the series comes from 17th-century poet John Milton's *Paradise Lost*, Book 2:

Into this wilde Abyss,
 The Womb of nature and perhaps her Grave,
 Of neither Sea, nor Shore, nor Air, nor Fire,
 But all these in their pregnant causes mixt
 Confus'dly, and which thus must ever fight,
 Unless th' Almighty Maker them ordain
His dark materials to create more Worlds,
 Into this wilde Abyss the warie fiend
 Stood on the brink of Hell and look'd a while,
 Pondering his Voyage; for no narrow frith
 He had to cross.

— *Paradise Lost*, Book 2, lines 910–920

Pullman earlier proposed to name the series *The Golden Compasses*, also a reference to *Paradise Lost*,^[6] where they denote God's circle-drawing instrument used to establish and set the bounds of all creation:



God as architect, wielding the golden compasses, by William Blake (left) and Jesus as geometer in a 13th-century medieval illuminated manuscript.

Then staid the fervid wheels, and in his hand
He took the golden compasses, prepared
In God's eternal store, to circumscribe
This universe, and all created things:
One foot he centered, and the other turned
Round through the vast profundity obscure

— *Paradise Lost*, Book 7, lines 224–229

Despite the confusion with the other common meaning of *compass* (the navigational instrument) *The Golden Compass* became the title of the American edition of *Northern Lights* (the book features an "alethiometer", a rare truth-telling device that one might describe as a "golden compass").

reflective of Christian teachings as Christians understand it.

I would like to start the conversation by asking the Archbishop, how we might tease out the differences.

Dr Rowan Williams: I suppose one of the questions I would like to hear more about from Philip is what has happened to Jesus in the church in this world [of His Dark Materials], because one of the interesting things for me in the model of the church in the plays and the books, is it's a church, as it were, without redemption.

It's entirely about control. And although I know that's how a lot of people do see the church, you won't be surprised to know that that's not exactly how I see it. Chance would be a fine thing! There is also the other question which I raised last week about the fascinating figure of The Authority in the books and the plays, who is God for all practical purposes in lots of people's eyes, but yet, of course, is not the Creator. So those are of course the kinds of differences that I am intrigued by here.

Philip Pullman: Well, to answer the question about Jesus first, ^{Jesus} ~~no, he~~ doesn't figure in the teaching of the church, as ~~he~~ described the church in the story. ~~I think~~ he's mentioned once, in the context of this notion of wisdom that works secretly and quietly, not in the great courts and palaces of the earth, but among ordinary people and so on. And there are some teachers who have embodied this quality, but whose teaching has perhaps been perverted or twisted or turned, and been used in a fashion that they themselves didn't either desire or expect or could see happening.

So there's a sort of reference to the teaching of Jesus which I may return to in the next book - but I don't want to anticipate too much because I've found that if I tell people what I'm going to write about, I don't write it, something happens to prevent it, so I'd better not anticipate that too much. But I'm conscious that that is a question that has been sort of hovering over people's understanding of the story anyway.

The figure of The Authority is ~~rather easier~~. In the sort of creation myth that underlies His Dark Materials, which is never fully explicit but which ^{he} ~~was~~ discovering as ^{he} ~~was~~ writing it, the notion is that there never was a Creator, instead there was matter, and this matter gradually became conscious of itself and developed Dust. Dust sort of precedes from matter as a way of

understanding itself. The Authority was the first figure that condensed, as it were, in this way and from then on he was the oldest, the most powerful, the most authoritative. And all the other angels at first believed he was the Creator and then some angels decided that he wasn't, and so we had the temptation and the Fall etc - all that sort of stuff came from that.

And the figure of Authority who dies in the story is well, one of the metaphors ^{he uses} ~~use~~. In the passage ^{he} ~~wrote~~ about his description, he was as light as paper - in other words he has a reality which is only symbolic. It's not real, and the last expression on his face is that of profound and exhausted relief. ~~That was important for me. That's not something you can easily show with a puppet to the back of the theatre.~~

RW: That's very helpful because I think it reinforces my sense that part of the mythology here was what came from some of those early Jewish and Christian or half Christian versions of the story in which you have a terrific drama of cosmic revolt. Someone is trying to pull the wool over your eyes is the underlying thing, and wisdom is an unmasking. ^{he seems to} ~~I think, if you have a view of God,~~ which makes God internal to the universe, that's what happens.

~~PP:~~ Yeah.

~~RW:~~ Someone is going to be pulling the wool over your eyes?

~~PP:~~ I suppose that's right ~~yes~~. The word that covers some of these early creation narratives is gnostic - the Gnostic heresy, as it became once Christianity was sort of defined. The idea that the world we live in, the physical universe is actually a false thing, made by a false God, and the true God, our true home, our true spiritual home is infinitely distant, far off, a long, long way away from that. This sense is something we find a lot of in popular culture, ~~don't you think? The X-Files, you know - "the truth is out there". The Matrix~~

Everything we see is the false creation of some wicked power that, ~~as you say,~~ is trying to pull the wool over our eyes, and there are many others. Can I just ask you a question for a minute? What do you put this down to? The great salience of gnostic feelings, gnostic sentiments and ways of thinking in our present world? What's the source of that, do you think? 12

RW: Well, let me try two thoughts on that. One is that the human sense that things are not in-

Robert Jordan's The Wheel of Time ~~is~~ "The Way of the Leaf"
~~is one that I really enjoy for its~~ ^{has} simplicity and yet complexity.

Essentially, it is a religion with one tenet: do no harm, ever, for any reason. - (Jarvis)

However, many practitioners in the world seem content to practice a form of ostracizing dissidents in their midst, which I believe can be harmful. This led me to thinking about it in general, and I decided that harm can come in many forms (physical, mental, social). Which seems obvious once it is thought out. The tricky part for many people is that the religion is not about **preventing** harm.

It is simply about **not causing** harm, but with the addendum that you prevent it so long as preventing harm does not cause harm.

J.K. Rowling Biography

Short Biography J K Rowling

J.K Rowling was born in Chipping Sodbury, July 31st, 1965. Her childhood was generally happy, although she does remember getting teased because of her name, "Rowling" – She recalls often getting called "Rowling pin" by her less than ingenious school friends. J.K. Rowling says she never really warmed to her own name, although, she does remember having a fondness for the name Potter from quite an early age. J.K. Rowling studied at St Michael's Primary School in Gloucestershire, before moving to Chepstow, South Wales at the age of nine.

From an early age, J.K. Rowling had the ambition to be a writer. She often tried her hand at writing, although little came from her early efforts. Aged six she wrote a book about a rabbit with measles. After her mother praised her effort. Rowling replied 'well get it published then.' She admits it was a 'Bit of an odd thing for a child of six to think. I don't know where it came from...'

In her own autobiography, she remembers with great fondness, when her good friend Sean became the first person to give her the confidence that one day she would be able to make a very good writer.

"he was also the only person who thought I was bound to be a success at it, which meant much more to me than I ever told him at the time" (1)

Sean was also the owner of a battered old Ford Anglia, which would later appear in one of the Harry Potter series as a flying car.

After finishing school, her parents encouraged her to study French at the University of Exeter. She slightly regretted choosing French, saying she would have preferred to study English. However, it was her parents wish that she study something "more useful" than English.

After having spent a year in Paris, J.K. Rowling graduated from university and took various jobs in London. One of her favourite jobs was working for Amnesty International; the charity, which campaigns against human rights abuses throughout the world. Amnesty International,



is one of the many charities, which J.K.Rowling has generously supported since she attained a new found wealth.

It was in 1990 that J.K.Rowling first conceived of the idea about Harry Potter. As she recalls, it was on a long train journey from Manchester to London when she began forming in her mind, the characters of the series. At the forefront, was a young boy, at that time not aware that he was a wizard. The train was delayed for over four hours, but she didn't have a pen and was too shy to ask for one nothing,

"To my immense frustration, I didn't have a pen that worked, and I was too shy to ask anybody if I could borrow one."

But she remembers being very enthusiastic, and excited about the ideas which were filling her mind.

On arriving at her flat in Clapham Junction, she began work on writing the book immediately, although, it would take several years to come to fruition.

It was also in December of 1990 that J.K.Rowling lost her mother, who died of Multiple Sclerosis. J.K.Rowling was very close to her mother, and she felt the loss deeply. Her own loss gave an added poignancy to the death of Harry Potter's mother in her book. She says her favourite scene in the *Philosopher's Stone* is, The Mirror of Erised, where Harry sees his parents in the mirror.

In 1991, J.K.Rowling left England to get a job as an English teacher in Portugal. It was here that she met her first husband, Jorge Arantes – and together they had a child Jessica. However, after a couple of years, the couple split after a fierce argument; where by all accounts J.K.Rowling was thrown out of the house.

In Dec 1993, Rowling returned to the UK, moving to Edinburgh where she tried to finish her first book. She was surviving on state benefits and bringing up her daughter as a single parent. She would often go to Edinburgh cafes to work on the book whilst her child had a nap.

Eventually, she finished her first copy of the *Philosopher's Stone*, and sent it off to various agents. She found an agent, Christopher, who spent over a year trying to get a publisher. It was rejected by 12 major publishing houses. But, eventually, a quite small publisher, Bloomsbury agreed to take the book on. The editor Barry Cunningham also agreed to pay her an advance of £1500. The decision to take on the book was, in large part, due to his eight-year-old daughter's enthusiastic reception of the first chapter (However she was advised to continue her training as a teacher because she was told writers of children's books don't tend to get very well paid.)

"There's always room for a story that can transport people to another place."

– J.K.Rowling [1]

Within a few weeks of publication, (1996) book sales really started to take off. The initial print run was of only 1,000 – 500 of which went to libraries. First editions are now said to be worth up to £25,000 each. She also received a grant from the Scottish arts council, which enabled her to write full time. After the books initial success in the UK, an American company Scholastic agreed to pay a remarkable £100,000 for the rights to publish in America. In 1998, Warner Bros secured the film rights to the books, giving a seven-figure sum. The films have magnified the success of the books, making Harry Potter into one of the most recognisable media products. Under the close guidance of J.K.Rowling, the films have sought to stay close to the original plot; also at J.K.Rowling's request all the actors are British and are filmed in Britain.

On the 21st December 2006, J.K.Rowling finished her final book of the Harry Potter Series – “*Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*“. The book was released in July 2007, becoming one of the fastest selling books of all time. J.K.Rowling has said the book is her favourite, and it makes her both happy and sad. She has said she will continue writing but there is little chance of continuing the Harry Potter Series. She has published a dictionary of things related to Hogwarts and Harry Potter, that were never published in other books.

Since the end of her Harry Potter series, she says she has finished some short stories, she also hinted on the Oprah Winfrey Show in 1st October 2010, that an 8th book in the Harry Potter series is a possibility.

On 27 September 2012, Rowling released the ‘Casual Vacancy’ an adult novel – to mixed reviews. In 2013, *The Cuckoo's Calling* was published. Initially, the author was stated as being Robert Galbraith. But, this was a pseudonym used by J.K.Rowling. After her authorship was discovered, sales went through the roof.

J.K.Rowling and Media

J.K.Rowling has sought to protect her children from media intrusion. In 2011, she gave testimony to the Leveson enquiry about how unscrupulous reporters sought to intrude into her family's privacy. After her books became best-sellers, reporters would often be camped outside her home. J.K. Rowling said:

“However, as interest in Harry Potter and myself increased, my family and I became the target of a different kind of journalistic activity. The effect on me, and our family life, truly cannot be overstated. We were literally driven out of the first house I had ever owned (which faced almost directly onto the street) because of journalists banging on the door, questioning the neighbours and sitting in parked cars immediately outside the gate. Old friendships were tested as journalists turned up on their doorsteps, and offered money for stories on me.” (J.K.Rowling's Testimony to Leveson Enquiry Nov 2011.)

After finding a letter from a journalist in her child's satchel, she remarked:

“It's very difficult to say how angry I felt that my 5-year-old daughter's school was no

longer a place of complete security from journalists."

J.K. Rowling currently lives in Scotland, on the banks of the river Tay, with her 2nd husband Neil Murray; J.K. Rowling has three children, two with husband Neil.

Wealth of J.K. Rowling

In 2017, according to Forbes, her estimated wealth stands at \$650 million, it would be higher but she has donated substantial sums to charity. The global Harry Potter brand is estimated to be worth £7 billion.

Charity Work of J.K. Rowling

J.K. Rowling has contributed considerable sums to charities she supports. This includes:

- **Anti-Poverty.** She is President of the Charity – One Parent Families
- **Multiple sclerosis.** She has contributed money to the research and treatment of Multiple Sclerosis, which her mother suffered from.
- **Lumos** – helping institutionalised children in Eastern Europe

Political Views

She has publically supported the Labour party. In 2008, she donated £1 million to the Labour party, saying she felt vulnerable families would be better off under a Labour government. She describes her political hero as Robert F. Kennedy.

Religious Views

J.K. Rowling states that she considers herself a Christian, and attends a local Church of Scotland congregation. She said, that unlike other members in her family, she often had a deep interest in religion, and would go to churches alone. However, she also says that although she believes in God, at times she doubts her faith.

"I feel very drawn to religion, but at the same time I feel a lot of uncertainty. I live in a state of spiritual flux. I believe in the permanence of the soul."

– J.K. Rowling (2008, interview in El Pais – a Spanish Newspaper)

More facts about J.K. Rowling

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Who is J.K. Rowling? at Amazon

Alchemy is so misunderstood that to say the Harry Potter books are built on alchemical structures and imagery is, to many readers, not much different from saying the books aren't worth reading or that they are dangerous to read.

One of the first lessons in chemistry class is that it grew out of the pseudoscience, alchemy whose goal was to create the "philosopher's stone" that could turn lead into gold and bestow immortality on the alchemist.

What alchemy is really about is turning something common into something special. It was about a spiritual path within the revealed religions to return fallen man to his Edenic perfection. Rowling uses alchemy in Harry Potter as a metaphor for change and as a resource for powerful imagery.

All the great writers, to some degree, use alchemical imagery. Shakespeare's plays are written on alchemical themes. In a proper tragedy, the audience identifies with the hero in his/her agony and shares in their passion. the audience experiences their "hero's journey" and are 'purified' along with the actors on stage or in a book.

The idea that reading was entertainment and diversion is a new idea, actually only the past 70 or 80 years. The rule in traditional cultures, and even in cultures such as ours, is that stories, in whatever form, are meant to instruct and change us.

What is Alchemy?

Before getting into how ~~Bowling uses alchemy~~ I want to first explain ~~where it comes from and what it is.~~

This whole tradition, including alchemy, comes from Egypt and is known as the Hermetic tradition. It includes, not only alchemy, but numerology, gnosticism and even astrology.

From Egypt there have survived 18 tractates generally known as the corpus Hermeticum. These scriptures of a small, mystic sect which honored the Egyptian God Thoth identified with the Greek god Hermes, under the title Trismegistos' or 'thrice greatest'. They date from the 1st cent. AD and bring together wisdom from Egypt, Greece and Asia.

All are concerned to declare a divine revelation. Initiation begins with a call to repentance: Then comes personal instruction so the initiate was required to turn away from ignorance, grief, intemperance, sensuality, injustice, avarice, folly, envy, deceit, anger, impetuosity and malice and embrace knowledge of God with joy, self-control, continence, righteousness, generosity, truth, goodness, life and light.

This involved ascetic discipline and self-discipline.

From this the initiate passed to silent meditation in solitude and then the climax was an ecstatic vision of LIGHT, delightful and joyous. This light is described as "the first God" and this knowledge of god is the human's salvation. by this alone can a soul become good. It is a re-birth and a sense of identity with all creation. Earth, air, fire and water, as well as plants and animals. More, it is to enter into God.

ALCHEMY, wrote Pierre-Jean Fabre in 1636, is not merely an art or science to teach metallic translations, so much as a true and solid science that teaches how to know the center of all things, which in the divine language is called the Spirit of Life."

Essential to alchemy is the understanding of "correspondences" between the material and the spiritual. "As above, so below."

Thus the alchemist was seeking under suitable astrological conditions to bring together primary matter and the primary agent (also called secret fire.)

First, to produce a pure mercurial substance, then an incombustible sulphur and finally the 'philosopher's stone', which had the power of transmuting base metals into gold, but whose discovery was also a necessary part of the realization of the human's full faculties, and a precondition of the discovery of the panacea, the elixir of life, which would transmute the human body into an incorporate body of light, so securing for the Adept omniscience, omnipotence and the joy of divine love.

Thus, the human being is the true subject of the alchemist's art. The three principles, Sulphur of his earthly part, Salt of the intellect and above all, Mercury, the mercury of the wise, "snowy splendour", the spark of the soul, the mystical spirit, must be brought together in the Azoth or Philosopher's Egg set within the Cauldron, which is the human itself.

This is done by the fire of love. than the transmutation of natural into spiritual human may begin.

The first stage of the process is Blackness, the stage of purgation

The second stage is whiteness, the stage of illumination

the third stage, or climax, is redness, the color of alchemical gold, and is also called the marriage of Luna and Sol, the human and the divine, the finite with the infinite

There are many books, including "Lord of the Rings", that are designed to trigger a powerful experience but the difference is that Rowling uses these images and symbols extensively and deliberately to great effect. She even talks about it in a 1998 interview. She says:

"I've never wanted to be a witch, but an alchemist. . . . To invent this wizard world, I've learned a ridiculous amount about alchemy. . . . I have to know in detail what magic can and cannot do in order to set the parameters and establish the stories' internal logic."

①

Alchemy appears everywhere in HP. In book titles, the first book was called Harry Potter and the Philosopher's stone but an American editor didn't think the word philosophy in the title would sell so changed it for American audiences to "sorcerer's stone". This obscured the main point of Rowling's plan and created a real problem with right wing Christians.

the characters are alchemical. Albus Dumbledore is an alchemist of renown and a partner to a real famous alchemist, Nicolas Flamel, who was an actual famous alchemist who lived in 14th century Paris. Hermione Granger's name is the feminine form of Hermes, who, besides being the

messenger of the gods, was also the name of the great alchemist Hermes Trismegistos, in whose name countless alchemical works were written thru the centuries. Even Harry's father, James, was named for the patron saint of alchemists and his mother, Lily, a symbol for the second purifying stage of the alchemical work.

AS we have already discussed, The alchemical work is about changing the soul from lead to gold, from failing to virtue. This is evident in each book in Harry's transformations that take place in each book.

In Philosopher's stone the orphaned Harry lives in fear of his aunt and uncle w/o any knowledge of who he is. By the books end, he shows himself a champion of remarkable courage and has become reconciled to his parents death and to his own destiny as a wizard.

In Chamber of Secrets he begins the book as a prisoner of the Dursleys and his own self-doubts and self pity. At the heroic finish, he risks his own life to liberate Ginny (read Virgin) and vanquish the villain who is an incarnation of selfishness and self-importance.

In Prisoner of Azkaban he begins by blowing up his Aunt Marge in anger. In the end, he rescues the man who betrayed his parents to Voldemort by offering his own life as a shield to him. He goes from unforgiving judgment to selfless mercy in a year in the 3rd book.

In Goblet of Fire he is initially consumed by worry of what others think of him and by books end, after trials with his best friend, a dragon, and other problems, he is able to shrug off a front-page hatchet job in wizarding world's main newspaper, "the Daily Prophet".

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In The Order of the Phoenix. Harry is consumed by a desire for news from anywhere. At the end, he is aware of his need to turn inward and to discover and strengthen his inner life. He knows that his dependence on the outer world and its events was his point of vulnerability which Voldemort used to manipulate him and that this weakness caused his godfathers death.

When Harry comes onto the scene in Half-blood prince, he is half asleep as he waits for Dumbledore to come for him. He is even worried about Dumbledore's concern for him. by the end he is ready to take on the mission that Dumbledore has given him even tho the headmaster is dead.

As with the hero's journey finale in Deathly Hallows. Harry's alchemical transformation in that book is the stunning ending to which all previous transformations turned out to be only pointers or foreshadowing.

At books beginning, Harry's faith in Dumbledore is all but broken by Rita Skeeter's revelations about him. Harry chooses to believe in Dumbledore. After Dobby's death, despite his doubts and what he has learned, Harry realizes that the search for horcruxes which will bring Lord Voldemort's special protection from death to an end is his goal rather than the power of the deathly hallows. This empowers Harry's great change into the "Christ" figure who rises from King's Cross after being 'killed' by Voldemort.

Harry's final transformation from doubter to believer and to vanquisher of both his internal failings and the external evil of Voldemort completes the seven stage alchemical work.

The design of each of the books parallels the alchemical work. Harry's two closest friends, Ron, the redheaded passionate boy and Hermione Granger, the brilliant, cool young woman. Ron represents sulfur and Hermione (HG = symbol for) mercury. Harry's friendships with these two transform him from lead into gold. Sulfur and Mercury are often called the "quarreling couple" an apt idea for Ron and Hermione.

We have already discussed the hero's journey in each book but each book also mirrors the alchemical transformation, the three stages, of the journey.

Characters are named for these stages. the first stage, called the nigredo, or black stage. the book, Order of the Pheonix, is the black stage of the whole series and Sirius Black is the featured and it ends with his death.

The second stage is purification, usually called the albedo or white work. When matter reaches this stage it has become pure and spotless, brilliant white. Albus Dumbledore (Albus, is latin for White) is named for this stage. Other symbols for this stage include the moon (Luna, one of Harry's friends), and a lily, the name of his mother. This book, The Half Blood Prince, ends with Dumbledore's death.

The last stage is the recongealing or perfection called the red stage. Rubeus (latin for red) Hagrid is named for this stage. The red lion is the symbol. Deathly Hollows is the big crucible finish to the series. Rubeus Hagrid doesn't die but Fred Weasley, a red head, does as do many others in the battle.

go to p. 9
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Each of the books in the series follows the alchemical three stages. The black work is the work done in Harry at the Dursley's and in Hogwarts classroom by Snape, the teacher that seems to hate him.

The white work, or purification occurs under the watchful eye of Albus Dumbledore during Harry's time at Hogwarts.

The red work is always in the climactic scene and is always underground or in a graveyard, in which Harry dies a figurative death and is saved by love in the presence of some Christological symbol.

The resurrection at story's end each year is the culmination of that year's cycle and transformation. The cycle closes with congratulations and explanations from the master alchemist, Dumbledore, and a return to the Dursleys for another trip thru the cycle. Of course, the last book ends with Harry actually dying and rising and ends his journey to perfection.

CONCLUSION:

The reason good authors use these alchemical images is because the three stages of the alchemical process and the whole "Great Work" of alchemy parallels the spiritual stages of transformation common to all the world's great religions.

Great writers in the English tradition have used alchemical imagery from the 16th to the present century because it works in grabbing hold of the readers hearts and bringing them to the imaginative place of transformation.

a big piece of this world wide phenomenon springs from people's individual and collective response, largely unconscious, to Rowling's traditional alchemical artistry and the spiritual message it carries.

THEMES IN HARRY POTTER

How do you decide if a book is worth reading? In these books we find the answer to four principal questions.

- *How are we to treat one another?
- *What is the answer to the mystery of death?
- *When are we to embrace change or flee change?
- *What makes a human being good or bad, or even human?

In the Harry Potter books it is prejudice that is the problem. In this regard these are not "kids books." The message of HP is clear: poisonous prejudice is everywhere, and only constant vigilance and resistance to the regime of ideas (whose government and media authorities foster and codify this hatred) will free us of it.

The HP books encourage readers to take a step back from the world and recognize what an unloving place it is. This step back is the first necessary step to any spiritual life. The ladder of divine ascent in every revealed tradition requires recognizing the fallen world for what it is.

It is in Order of the phoenix we find out how inbred and insular the leading magical families have become over the generations and how their narrow belief in eugenics or 'good breeding' have taken them into the dark lords service. Thus, they have divided their world into pure bred and mudbloods, those who are witches but are not pure. These have muggle, ie human, parents. Hermione Granger is one of these. It is the same thinking that created Nazi camps and soviet gulags.

What all these characters learn is that none are either all good or all bad. The revelation for her is that we readers are the prejudiced ones. Every novel ends with a surprise that all were not what they seemed.

These books are read and re-read because they offer the right answer. That answer is LOVE. prejudice is a failure in love. We recognize in these stories the desire to see what makes us feel best about ourselves even if it means being unkind or dismissive of others.

Harry has to overcome his prejudice of Severus Snape and accept that it was Severus love for Harry's mother, Lily, that has kept him alive all these years. Harry was able to sacrifice himself in love for his friends because he has the darkness within himself.

That love as the solution to prejudice so dominates the story line of all these books makes it in the tradition of the Inklings, and Christian literature in general.

* * * * *

DEATH AS HER MAIN THEME.

.. Rowling lost her mother to MS in 1990, the same year she conceived of the Harry Potter books. She said, "In fact, death and bereavement and what death means. . . is one of the central themes of all seven books."

Every book develops the theme of love trumping death. However, it is in the first book that she has Dumbledore explain about love and death.

"your mother died to save you. If there is one thing Voldemort cannot understand, it is love. He didn't realize that love as powerful as your mother's for you leaves its own mark. Not a scar, no visible sign. . . to have been loved so deeply even tho the person who loved us is gone, will give

us some protection forever. It is in your very skin. Quirrell, full of hatred, greed and ambition, sharing his soul with Voldemort, could not touch you for this reason. It was agony to touch a person marked by something so good."

Thus, in the opening book, Philosopher's Stone, Rowling offers explicit teaching of what death is and the importance of the love of those departed that continues to protect us even in their absence. Especially when this love was a sacrificial love.

This is the major difference between Voldemort and Harry. Voldemort, fearing death pursues personal immortality by putting parts of his own soul into physical objects so if he dies, he still continues to live. These Horcruxes have been created by killing people. this separates him from any love of others as he invests in material things to survive. Fleeing human death, Voldemort becomes its nonliving, inhuman incarnation.

In contrast, when given Dumbledore's choice between what is good and what is easy, Harry always chooses the good even tho it means the probable loss of his physical life. He does so at the moment of crises in every book.

The war between the forces of good and evil that defines the final three novels of the series is largely between those who think physical life (existence) and advantage or power are the greatest goods and those who think what gives life meaning (the soul's ability to lov and laugh) is more real and important than just what is visible.

So, Rowling is saying that physical death is not the greatest evil but living a soulless existence in fear of death is the true death of the human spirit and the greater evil.

Thus, Harry in the final book, when Severus Snapes memories reveal that he must die if Voldemort is to be defeated and that he must die without fighting back. Harry walks into the forbidden Forest and lays down his life voluntarily accompanied by his mother and father.

Thus, Harry understood what Dumbledore had been trying to tell him. The difference between being dragged into battle to face death and walking into the arena with head held high.

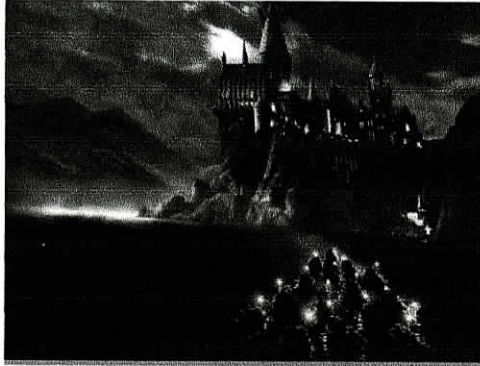
To defeat the dark lord Harry has to transcend his ego concerns, even his inherited prejudices and doubts. That is, He has a destiny but his freewill choices are what will make the difference between his realizing his prophesied end or not.

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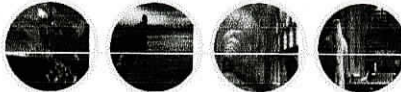
4 Ways Harry Potter Mirrors the Christian Story

There's little doubt that the Christian tradition informs much of Rowling's beloved series.

By Patrick McCauley



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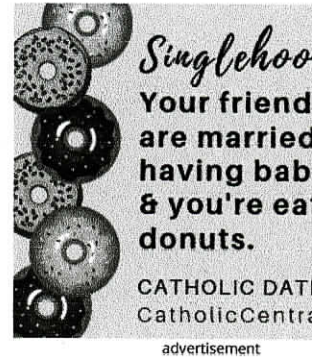


In her interview with Oprah Winfrey, J. K. Rowling acknowledged that the Harry Potter series had a deep and intentional connection to Christianity. She said, "There is a lot of Christian imagery in the books. That's undeniable. And certainly in *Hallows* [it is] very clear . . . That's an allusion to a belief system in which I was raised."

However, many of us remember early resistance to the Harry Potter series from our Christian parents and Pope Benedict alike. That started to abate with the publication of books like *Looking for God in Harry Potter* by John Granger, which helped many Christians find an ally in Harry Potter where previously they had seen a potential risk.

In *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*, the last book in the series, Rowling includes overt references to Matthew 6:19, "Where you treasure is, there will your heart be also" and 1 Corinthians 15:26, "The last enemy that shall be destroyed is death" (see *Harry Potter and the Deathly Hallows*, pp. 325, 328).

Despite the fact that Rowling's books are loaded to the brim with witches, potions, and evil incantations, there can be little doubt that the Christian tradition informs much of Harry's story. Here are five ways J.K. Rowling's beloved series mirrors the Christian narrative.



5 Ways Harry Potter Mirrors the Christian Story

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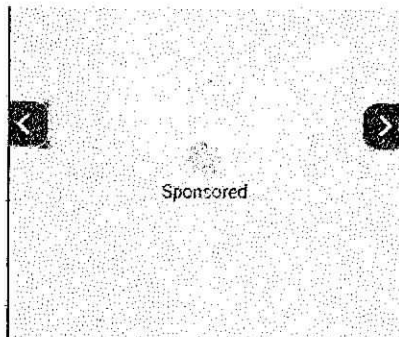
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Albus Dumbledore — John the Baptist

In a conversation between J.K. Rowling and Daniel Radcliffe, Rowling reveals that Albus Dumbledore is "John the Baptist to Harry's Christ." This is echoed in *Harry Potter and the Half-Blood Prince* where Dumbledore says of Harry, "But your blood is worth more than mine."

When we read the Gospel of Mark, we tend to see a John who might be seen as coaching Jesus, much in the manner Dumbledore coaches Harry. It is only after He has gone to see John that Jesus decides to go into the desert and face temptation. I think Rowling is saying something very powerful in her assertion that it is Dumbledore — that is, John the



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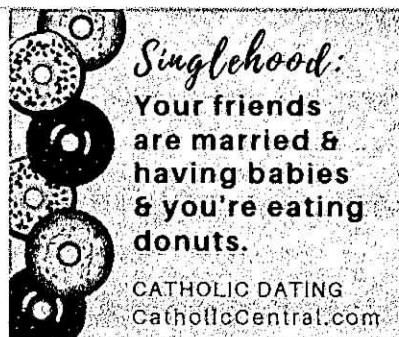
Illustration by Rick Brown



The Room for Requirement as The Room of Hidden Things — Forgiveness

One of the most engaging magical elements of Hogwarts castle is the Room for Requirement. It is a room that magically and intuitively becomes whatever the entrant needs it to be. But the Room has another name: the Room of Hidden Things. When the room becomes the Room of Hidden Things, therein rest the "objects hidden by generations of Hogwarts inhabitants" (See *Half-Blood Prince*, p. 526). When a student comes to hide something, he or she sees every other object that has ever been hidden in the Room. So why would the Room of Requirement do something that is not required?

Perhaps it actually is doing something that is required — but what? The Room makes it inescapably clear that I am not alone in my desire to hide indiscretions and bad decisions. The Room does not provide easy mercy or undeserved reassurance. It does, however, allow the student who may be at his most lonely and isolated moment to see that he is not, in fact, the only one.



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Dobby's Grave — Death and Resurrection

"He heard the authority of his own voice, the conviction, the voice of purpose that had come to him as he dug Dobby's grave" (*Deathly Hallows*, p. 482).

The younger Harry who had complained about being left to "grope in the darkness" without a plan from Dumbledore is a Harry who is still in the last stages of his childhood reliance on guidance. The later Harry, the one who speaks with his own voice, with the voice of purpose and conviction, is no longer a child. We must remember that Harry dug Dobby's grave by hand.

"... he had set to work, alone, digging the grave... He dug with

a kind of fury... On Harry dug, deeper and deeper into the hard, cold earth, subsuming his grief in sweat... understanding blossomed in the darkness... He felt as though he had been slapped awake... Deeper and deeper Harry sank into the grave... Harry lost track of time... Harry placed the elf into the grave, arranged his tiny limbs so that he might have been resting, then climbed out" (*Deathly Hallows*, pp. 478-80).

Dobby is not the only one who goes into this grave. Harry descends into the "hard, cold earth" as well. There is something of Harry that is buried along with the elf. Yet, even as one part of Harry dies, another part rises.



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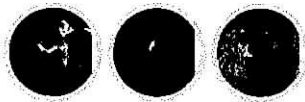
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Forbidden Forest — Gethsemane

In Mark 14:35, Jesus asks his Father to "Take this cup from me." Jesus is "overwhelmed with sorrow to the point of death." *we* like so many others, find this scene to be at the center of what it means to think about Christianity. Here we get a Jesus who seems so real and human that it is hard to believe that the text is 2,000 years old. A Jesus who is scared and overwhelmed is a Jesus *we* can relate to. It is in this scene that *we* meet, perhaps for the first time, a Jesus who feels fully human to *me*. *us*

J.K. Rowling built seven beautiful novels that lead us up to the desperately reluctant Harry walking into the Forbidden Forest

to face the mania of Tom Riddle. Rowling's description of Harry's walk into the woods, juxtaposes Harry's incredible desire to hold onto life against his determination to face his calling and responsibility. Rowling gives us no easy superman, no confident champion of courage. She gives us a Harry who feels this crazy struggle the way *we* imagine *we* would — terrified, despairing, and a hair's breadth from quitting. She gives us a Harry who makes it easy to imagine what all this might feel like if it were happening to *me*. Rowling's Jesus does not walk into the woods for *me*, not in place of *me*, but as *me*. *us*

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Summary

"I am not a Jew," said the man.

"To me [the religious parallels have] always been obvious," she said. "But I never wanted to talk too openly about it because I thought it might show people who just wanted the story where we were going."

Indeed, at its most simplistic, Harry's final tale can in some respects be boiled down to a resurrection story, with Harry venturing to a heavenly way station of sorts after getting hit with a killing curse in Chapter 35, only to shortly return. (Read how Rowling revealed the characters' fates to the "Harry Potter" movies' stars here.)

But if she was worried about tipping her hand narratively in the earlier books, she clearly wasn't by the time Harry visits his parents' graves in Chapter 16 of "Deathly Hallows," titled "Godric's Hollow." On his parents' tombstone he reads the quote "The last enemy that shall be destroyed is death," while on another tombstone (that of Dumbledore's mother and sister) he reads, "Where your treasure is, there will your heart be also."

While Rowling said that "Hogwarts is a multifaith school," these quotes, of course, are distinctly Christian. The second is a direct quote of Jesus from Matthew 6:19, the first from 1 Corinthians 15:26. As Hermione tells Harry shortly after he sees the graves, his parents' message means "living beyond death. Living after death." It is one of the central foundations of resurrection theology.

Which makes it a perfect fit for Harry, said Rowling, who was talking about those quotes for the very first time.

"They're very British books, so on a very practical note Harry was going to find biblical quotations on tombstones," Rowling explained. "[But] I think those two particular quotations he finds on the tombstones at Godric's Hollow, they sum up — they almost epitomize the whole series."

As the one to bring together all three magical Deathly Hallows, Harry, in fact, becomes the "Master of Death" by novel's end, able to bring back the spirits of his parents, his godfather, Sirius Black and his old teacher Remus Lupin. It's a conclusion

that ends Harry's three-book-long struggle over questions about the afterlife, which begins when Sirius falls through a veil connecting this world and the next at the end of "Order of the Phoenix."

"Deathly Hallows" itself begins with two religiously themed epigraphs, one from "The Libation Bearers" by Aeschylus, which calls on the gods to "bless the children"; and one from William Penn's "More Fruits of Solitude," which speaks of death as but "crossing the world, as friends do the seas." No other book in the series begins with epigraphs — a curious fact, perhaps, but one that Rowling insists served as a guiding light.

"I really enjoyed choosing those two quotations because one is pagan, of course, and one is from a Christian tradition," Rowling said of their inclusion. "I'd known it was going to be those two passages since 'Chamber' was published. I always knew [that] if I could use them at the beginning of book seven then I'd cued up the ending perfectly. If they were relevant, then I went where I needed to go.

"They just say it all to me, they really do," she added.

But while the book begins with a quote on the immortal soul — and though Harry finds peace with his own death at the end of his journey — it is the struggle itself which mirrors Rowling's own, the author said.

"The truth is that, like Graham Greene, my faith is sometimes that my faith will return. It's something I struggle with a lot," she revealed. "On any given moment if you asked me [if] I believe in life after death, I think if you polled me regularly through the week, I think I would come down on the side of yes — that I do believe in life after death. [But] it's something that I wrestle with a lot. It preoccupies me a lot, and I think that's very obvious within the books."

That, by the author's own acknowledgement, "Harry Potter" deals extensively with Christian themes may be somewhat ironic, considering that many Christian leaders

have denounced the series for glamorizing witchcraft. When he was known simply as Cardinal Joseph Ratzinger, the Pope himself condemned the books, writing that their "subtle seductions, which act unnoticed ... deeply distort Christianity in the soul before it can grow properly."

For her part, Rowling said she's proud to be on numerous banned-book lists. As for the protests of some believers? Well, she doesn't take them as gospel.

"I go to church myself," she declared. "I don't take any responsibility for the lunatic fringes of my own religion."

Harry Potter and the Inklings: The Christian Meaning of The Chamber of Secrets

by John Granger

Do you think I am trying to weave a spell? Perhaps I am; but remember your fairy tales. Spells are used for breaking enchantments as well as for inducing them. And you and I have need of the strongest spells that can be found to wake us from the evil enchantment of worldliness which has been laid upon us for nearly a hundred years.

C. S. Lewis, "The Weight of Glory"

A very famous writer once said, "A book is like a mirror. If a fool looks in, you can't expect a genius to look out."

J. K. Rowling on NBC's 'Today Show', 10/20/00

There has been no shortage of critics who dislike the Harry Potter books because they are (allegedly) poorly written and because (it seems to them) they teach an 'unbiblical spirituality.' *The Hidden Key to Harry Potter* (the book from which this essay is taken) is an attempt to begin filling a vacancy in the critical response to Joanne Rowling's best-selling Harry Potter books. Ms. Rowling also has a bevy of admirers that have written articles and books detailing her literary references and defending the use of magic in children's fantasy literature. No one to date, however, has tried to explain the Harry Potter phenomenon in light of Ms. Rowling's peculiar genius, the profound themes explored in the books, or her efforts to emulate the achievements of the Inklings Christian writers of the last century.

Why 'the high road approach' has been left vacant is something of a mystery. There are four reasons that come immediately to mind:

1) The Rowling Cinderella Story: Ms. Rowling made the mistake of telling reporters during the marketing of the first book that she had had some difficult times writing it. The story of her being a single mother on the dole striking it rich has since that time become the predominant image in people's minds because every media story about her includes it. This image has made it impossible for many to consider her work as they would, say, a book by Jane Austen or George Eliot. How many

welfare moms do you know who have double firsts in Classics and French from a prestigious university (as Ms. Rowling does) and the ability to write fiction drawing on ancient and medieval philosophy? I bet you can count them on one hand.

2) The Christian 'Magic' Controversy: The few stories in the popular press and broadcast media that do not focus on the Cinderella story are usually about the "magic" controversy. Several Christian groups and individuals have branded the Harry Potter books as satanic and gateways to the occult because of their magical milieu. This wrong-headed interpretation, almost 180 degrees off, remains an albatross around Ms. Rowling's neck. The thought that she is writing edifying Christian fiction is about as believable to most as the possibility that Osama bin Laden has been horribly misrepresented and is actually a Baptist minister living in Cherryville, North Carolina.

3) Classification as Children's Literature: Ms. Rowling did not set out to write children's books. Probably the major theme of the books is death and her treatment of this theme and others, drawing as it does from the richest streams of Western philosophy, theology, and traditionalism, is anything but childish or superficial. Serious readers, however, do not read the books or do not read them attentively or seriously because they believe children's books are beneath them or such critical attention.

4) Misogyny: And last but not least, it needs to be mentioned that Ms. Rowling has not been taken seriously because she is a woman. If a male Oxford University don had written these books, I am sure Harry Potter would have been put under the literary microscope for interpretation and in-depth analysis years ago. The Cinderella story doesn't help, certainly, but the ease with which that story has taken hold, despite the remarkable popularity and complexity of her books, reflects its only having served as confirmation of our persistent cultural conviction that women are stupid and helpless.

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Publishing Parallels

There is an interesting parallel of profound and ironic misunderstanding in C. S. Lewis's life that most of his Christian readers do not know. Before he became well known as a Christian, his published fiction was greeted with a yawn - and a confused yawn at that. *Out of the Silent Planet*, the first of the 'Space' or 'Ransom' trilogy, was met on its publication by reviewers and readers unable to understand it as the "smuggled theology" Lewis meant it to be. Though the book's Christian meaning is fairly plain, Lewis claimed that only two of sixty articles on the book

"showed any knowledge that my idea of the fall of the Bent One was anything but a private invention of my own. But if there only was someone with a richer talent and more leisure I think that this great ignorance might be a help to the evangelisation of England; any amount of theology can now be smuggled into people's minds under cover of romance without their knowing it" (Lewis to Sister Penelope, 9 July 1939, *Letters of C. S. Lewis*, pg. 167).

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David Downing, Lewis authority and author of *Planets in Peril: A Critical Study of C. S. Lewis's Ransom Trilogy*, checked the reviews to see if Lewis hadn't been exaggerating for effect in this letter. His research confirmed that the Christian cosmology and meaning of the book had indeed escaped the book's reviewers in 1938.

Lewis's mention of only two reviews in sixty sounds hyperbolic, but a survey of *Out of the Silent Planet* reviews confirms his reckoning as essentially accurate. One reviewer, for example, confesses that he read *Out of the Silent Planet* twice and still could not find an allegorical significance. Another concludes that "*Out of the Silent Planet*, beautifully written as some of it is, does not seem quite to have grown from any conviction." One can hardly imagine a more inaccurate observation. *Out of the Silent Planet* was written with all of Lewis's convictions, with his whole worldview, in the background (*Planets in Peril*, p.36).

This misunderstanding was not true of *Perelandra*, the second book of this trilogy, which is not any more obviously Christian. However, it was hailed as a Christian fiction at publication in 1943 and ever since. I think the reason why is fairly obvious; between the two books Lewis had 'come out of the closet'. By 1943 Lewis had made the radio broadcasts which eventually became *Mere Christianity* and published *Screwtape*, which two events together revealed him as a Christian artist and apologist. The author of *Silent Planet* had been assumed to be an atheist while the author of *Perelandra* was evidently a confessor of the faith.

Ms. Rowling, because of the rags-to-riches tale and no little misogyny, is enduring ~~similar~~ misunderstanding, albeit ignorance and slander greater by an order of magnitude. Lewis may not have been identified as a Christian writer (despite the seemingly transparent meaning of his fiction) but no one is on record as being shocked to learn that this Oxford Don was a Christian when he gave public witness of his faith. Imagine for contrast the response if Ms. Rowling were to make any statement of her religious beliefs!

The secret of Harry Potter, i.e., that it is Christian fiction, however, is evident in what we know of Ms. Rowling without a formal statement of her spiritual creed. She has a superior formal education in Classics and French in addition to a working familiarity with ancient and medieval philosophy and literature. This intellectual backdrop is evident in the Harry Potter books' language, mythological references, and philosophical underpinnings.

She has also said that she is a great admirer of the Inklings, especially Lewis. When compared with him, she says that Lewis is a genius and she is not, which response suggests that she sees him as something of a mentor. She admits to being physically incapable of being in the same room with a Narnia book and not sitting down to read it.

If she had not said these things, the many allusions to Narnia and Lewis's books on education and literature would have brought us to the same conclusion. The professor hero in the Narnia books, for example, is named 'Digory Kirke' and is Lewis's self-portrait; Dumbledore's forceful admonition to us in *Goblet* to 'Remember Cedric Diggory' is a

flashing neon road sign directing critical traffic to her role model.

Her similarity to Lewis is not limited to writing charming fantasies for children (that have magic in them) as not a few of her defenders against Christian criticism imply. The Harry Potter books are the whole Inkling show, to include training in the "stock responses", right alignment of the soul's faculties, and most important, the 'baptism of the imagination' in Christian symbols and doctrines. Rowling's books are 'instructions while delighting' in the real world struggle to choose love and life in ~~in~~ Christ over hatred, prejudice and spiritual death.

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Not that these books don't have a biting satirical and sardonic edge. 'Harry Potter' is a traditionalist broadside attack on the modern world and its absurdities. Rowling's traditionalism shows itself in her profound use of alchemical symbolism in every book and the medieval and magical setting of Hogwarts. She creates a technology free, virtue laden world in order to critique modernity's obsession with toys and neglect of everything meaningful. She fills this world with magic as a counter spell to break the materialist enchantment of our effeminate, one-dimensional culture. Harry is a Christian hero, and a masculine icon of the traditionalist, symbolic outlook to boot.

(4)

Nowhere is this more evident than in the second Harry Potter novel, *Harry Potter and the Chamber of Secrets*. It is the most explicitly Christian of the series and the most didactic about the dangers and delights of reading books. This explicitness is understandable in light of the response to the first book, *Philosopher's Stone*, a response that must have been surprising to Ms. Rowling.

What was the response to the publication of *Philosopher's Stone*? It sold very well. Scholastic Books bid six figures for the American publishing rights. Some Christian groups, not just peripheral fundamentalist sects but several mainline churches in England and America, objected to the magical milieu of Harry's world. Other reviewers rushed to its defense (usually reducing the objections to a straw man and defending all fantasy and fiction), a few noted the literary references.

The success of the books certainly stunned Ms. Rowling, who claims earnestly she had no idea they would prove so popular. What must have been at least as surprising - and disappointing considering their sales - was that there was no interpretation of the book per se and no defense of the book from the position that it is a remarkably Christian book. *Philosopher's Stone*, despite its being a tale of the soul's purification, illumination, and perfection in Christ (written in the medieval language of spiritual alchemy) and heavy with traditional Christian symbols from the golden griffin to the Philosopher's Stone, was read by many as occult fantasy.

Ms. Rowling bristles at the Christian objections to her books, especially those that suggest she is a Satan worshipper. She remarked at the release of *Goblet of Fire* that it and *Chamber of Secrets* were the hardest to write and her favorite books. ~~She doesn't tell us why Chamber was hard to write or became her favorite but I have a good guess.~~

~~Chamber of Secrets operates on several levels. As in all the books, it tells a rollickin' good yarn while advancing the larger story of Harry and~~

(5)

Voldemort. But *Chamber* is also an answer to her Christian critics within the story and a 'book about books' to boot. It couldn't have been easy to write but, ~~I have to agree with her~~, it is the best single volume of the series. It is, simultaneously:

- A wonderful mystery/adventure story, tightly plotted;
- that moves the larger story line along with revelations about Riddle and others; and
- a response to critics via a textbook demonstration of the meaning and power of Inklings literature.

As a book about books, *Chamber* discusses the quality, value and dangers of three books: Riddle's Diary, Lockhart's corpus, and the Harry Potter book the reader is holding and experiencing. ~~Let's see what she has to tell us about each of these books and speculate on her real world referents.~~

(5)

The Danger of Tom Riddle's Diary

Chamber turns on the diary of Tom Riddle (a.k.a., Lord Voldemort) and what happens when it returns to Hogwarts. When Harry and Ron discover the diary in Moaning Myrtle's toilet, Ron warns Harry about the dangerous magic in books.

no Harry looked under the sink where Myrtle was pointing. A small, thin book lay there. It had a shabby black cover and was as wet as everything else in the bathroom. Harry stepped forward to pick it up, but Ron suddenly flung out an arm to hold him back.
"What?" said Harry.
"Are you crazy?" said Ron. "It could be dangerous."
"Dangerous?" said Harry, laughing. "Come off it, how could it be dangerous?"

yes "You'd be surprised," said Ron, who was looking apprehensively at the book. "Some of the books the Ministry's confiscated - Dad's told me - there was one that burned your eyes out. And everyone who read *Sonnets of a Sorcerer* spoke in limericks for the rest of their lives. And some old witch in Bath had a book that you could never stop reading! You had to just wander around with your nose in it, trying to do everything one-handed. And..."
"All right, I've got the point," said Harry. The little book lay on the floor, nondescript and soggy.
"Well, we won't find out unless we look at it," he said, and he ducked around Ron and picked it up off the floor"
(*Chamber*, pages 230-231)

yes Rowling is having a little fun here. Notice the Sorcerer book title and what it does. 'Sorcerer' is a word rarely used in Harry Potter but it is in the title of the American edition of *Philosopher's Stone*. Could she be accusing her American Christian critics of making laughable accusations? Few if any of those who read *Stone*, after all, have ~~marginally been transformed into~~
Wicca even deities,

~~magically been transformed into Wicca coven devotees~~

Harry, after Ron's hysterical warnings and barely concealed prediction of a fate worse than death, decides he'll have to read it to find out. I don't doubt that Rowling is saying that this is the course of the sensible, sober reader; in the matter of a controversial or supposedly dangerous book, read it and decide for yourself what it is about.

What we know for sure, though, is that she is not dismissing the possibility that books can be dangerous. Riddle's diary certainly is. Let's lay out what we know about this diary:

- It is Tom Marvolo Riddle's (a.k.a., Lord Voldemort)
- delivered by Lucius Malfoy -
- in a Transfiguration Textbook -
- to Ginny Weasley.

Lucius Malfoy's intentions in planting the book in Ginny Weasley's textbook are not, as one might think, to restore Lord Voldemort. That Malfoy could have done on his own, Quirrell like, with any stooge. Dumbledore tells us the book planting was a "clever plan" to undermine Arthur Weasley's standing among wizards and destroy the Muggle Protection Act Weasley sponsors (*Chamber*, page 335-336). Mr. Malfoy is understandably nervous about this Act and the raids the Ministry has been making to round up 'dangerous toys' from dark wizards. Draco Malfoy also suggests that his father was trying to remove the 'muggle loving' Headmaster, Albus Dumbledore, from Hogwarts, which he did, at least for a while.

'What the diary does' highlights Rowling's point about authentically dangerous books. The diary in *Chamber*, as an example of such books, is a book in which:

- The innocent (again, 'Ginny' here should be read as 'Virginia' or 'virgin')
- are transfigured (note the Transfiguration textbook in which Malfoy hides the diary)
- into the wicked (it is the possessed Ginny that opens the Chamber and releases the Basilisk)
- by the author of a book of dark magic (Riddle/Voldemort is the bad guy)
 - hidden inside their textbooks and pretending to be what they are not.

The effect of the book on Ginny is that she turns into a rooster murdering, basilisk releasing servant of Riddle. She thinks she is losing her mind and she is right; her mind is Voldemort's and in this is the death of her innocence and purity. The effect of the book on Harry, too, is remarkable. After his time inside the memory of Tom Riddle he more than half believes that Hagrid is the heir of Slytherin. It is a pretty powerful drug or 'confundus charm' - or evil magic - that could make Harry suspect his friend, the Dumbledore-adoring gamekeeper.

The Really Dangerous Books

Rowling isn't telling us to beware of the sneaky diaries of dark wizards. She is pointing to the dangers hiding in children's textbooks. In this, she follows C. S. Lewis, who discusses just this problem in his book *The Abolition of Man*. The lead essay, "Men Without Chests", exposes the harm done by the insidious and sentiment destroying 'moral philosophy' of textbook writers. His powerful conclusion:

The operation of *The Green Book* and [textbooks of] its kind is to produce what may be called Men without Chests. It is an outrage that they should be commonly spoken of as intellectuals. This gives them the chance to say that he who attacks them attacks Intelligence. It is not so. They are not distinguished from other men by any unusual skill in finding truth nor any virginal ardour to pursue her. Indeed, it would be strange if they were: a persevering devotion to truth, a nice sense of intellectual honour, cannot be long maintained without the aid of a sentiment which [the textbook writers] could debunk as easily as any other. It is not excess of thought but defect of fertile and generous emotion that marks them out. Their heads are no bigger than the ordinary: it is the absence of the chest beneath that makes them seem so.

And all the time - such is the tragic-comedy of our situation - we continue to clamour for those very qualities we are rendering impossible. You can hardly open a periodical without coming across the statement that what our civilization needs is more drive, or dynamism, or self-sacrifice, or 'creativity.' In a sort of ghastly simplicity we remove the organ and demand the function. We make men without chests and expect of them virtue and enterprise. We laugh at honour and are shocked to find traitors in our midst. We castrate and bid the geldings be fruitful. (*Abolition of Man*, pages 34-35).

In other words, the hidden 'dark wisdom' in our children's schoolbooks is transforming them from something human into people who are somehow less than human. Because of their having grown up "having read the wrong sort of books" (see Eustace Scrubb in Lewis's *Voyage of the Dawn Trader*), they are incapable of the sentiments and emotions that buttress and create courage and the other moral excellences. Rowling communicates this real danger of the vacant naturalism and godlessness in textbooks through the mind of Tom Riddle hidden in Ginny's Transfiguration schoolbook. This danger is so much more real today, having won the day, if you will, that it is perhaps less apparent to us than it would have been in Lewis's time. Which is, I think, also part of Rowling's intended response to the objections to Magic in her books. We have already read Lewis's response to his own Christian critics; magic, he explained, can be a counter-spell and magic in edifying fiction is just that - a counter-spell to the enchantment of modernity. Let's look at that enchantment for a moment, because understanding Rowling's attack on it in her books is one way to appreciate her genius and the Tragico-magic objections of some Christians.

opposites) and the material things in which these three qualities appear to us are 'as grass in the fire' - is both the root of the symbolist outlook contra materialism and the genius of Rowling's use of magic. Rowling's magical world, existing alongside the pale, materialist Muggle world, is the same world experienced 'diagonally' which reveals what is eternal in the ephemeral, the quality in the quantity.

'Diagon Alley' as not a few critics have noted is word play for 'diagonally'. This street hidden in the heart of London is a magical avenue of commerce with a Wizard's bank (run by goblins), a wand shop, and the best bookstore. The numbers on this street are without exception prime numbers or the product of primes (see Philip Nel, J.K. Rowling's *Harry Potter Novels*, pages 31-32). Is this just cleverness run amuck or is Rowling telling us something?

Rowling asks us to look at the world magically, which is to say, not accepting that what we see is all there is. Seen 'diagonally', material things (to include people!) are better understood in light of their qualities, their beauty, truth, and virtue. Rowling in her use of prime numbers points us to consider even quantities, what we measure in number, as qualities; primes differ in quality from other numbers in their being irreducible to lesser constituents. Look, she says, for what is irreducible and eternal in the world rather than for only its 'straight on', ephemeral, quantitative value.

And the magic? 'Magic' is activity not obedient to naturalist law and material quantities. Rowling is writing a broadside, Christian attack on 'the reign of quantity', error, evil, and ugliness in the modern world; what better place to cast the counter spell to the enchantment of modernity than in a technology free world of magic alongside our own? And, yet, because of the poetry of magic she uses in her defense of the greater view, she has drawn fire from the very community she defends.

405 The irony of Christian objections to Harry Potter is that they are uniformly made against their magic and occult elements. There is a real danger in the occult, and I protect my children from any exposure to it, even in popular culture. Objections to the magic in Harry Potter, however, mistake the edifying use of magic in literature for actual invocational sorcery condemned by Scripture which it clearly is not.

The far more prevalent and spiritually damning danger is the materialist world-view of our time, the world-view attacked by Johnson with his 'Wedge' war and Rowling in her fiction. Naturalism makes Christian belief, or any revealed faith, ridiculous; it reduces, in its monopoly of public discourse, the path to communion with Truth down to a private struggle individuals may attempt on the far periphery of the public square.

Those who object to her magic do so with good intentions I am sure; they are blind, however, to the great service she does them in her attack on the mortal, invisible enemy inside our gates. It is the materialist heresy that undermines and belittles the traditional world-view of Christianity. It is naturalism that immunizes hearts to graces available from the two-fold revelation of God in nature and scripture. In comparison to this spiritual cancer, in reaction to which many souls are attracted to 'spiritualism', the dangers of magic and the occult are mostly in that they distract us from the greater evil.

The Significance of Gilderoy Lockhart

Chamber is the Harry Potter 'book about books'. We have looked at the 'portrait of evil' Rowling paints in Riddle's diary of the dark, moral philosophy hiding in modernist textbooks; let's move on to the most comic figure in the Potter series, Gilderoy Lockhart.

First, the bad news. Rowling has said in interviews that Gilderoy Lockhart will not return. Any of you having bet on his being the next Defense Against the Dark Arts teacher will have to pay up; *Chamber* will be his only appearance.

~~But there is good news.~~ In an interview with amazon.com, she mentioned that Gilderoy Lockhart "started as an exaggeration version of a person I've met." That person is not difficult to identify - and this identification reveals another sort of dangerous book that Rowling warns her attentive reader about. *Break With a Banshee, Gadding with ghouls, Holidays with Hags, Travels with Trolls, Voyages with Vampires, Wanderings with Werewolves, Year with the Yeti, Gilderoy Lockhart's Guide to Household Pets, Magical Me* - Gilderoy Lockhart has written a bunch of books. Here is what we know about them:

- Their only purpose is to generate money and fame for Gilderoy;
- The adventure stories are all other magical persons' accomplishments; and
- Women (that is, witches) love them, wizards do not.

What we learn about Gilderoy, himself, beyond his being "Order of Merlin, Third Class, Honorary Member of the Dark Force Defense League, and five time winner of Witch Weekly's Most-Charming-Smile Award" (which he "won't talk about" but manages to mention four times in *Chamber*), is:

- He is despised by the teachers as an empty headed braggart;
- He is adored by the girl students but he sickens the boys;
- He lives for publicity, large photos of himself, and other people's admiration;
- He favors effeminate colors in robes (jade, lilac, midnight blue, etc.);
- He has one good charm (the memory charm); and
- He is a Coward, 'Order of Scaredy Cat, First Class.'

His cowardice is revealed in spades when Ginny Weasley is taken into the Chamber of Secrets by Riddle and the teachers tell Lockhart he has a "free rein at last" to slay the monster. When Harry and Ron go to him to explain where they think the Chamber is, he tells them this sort of work wasn't "in the job description":

"You mean you're *running away*?" said Harry disbelievingly.
"After all that stuff you did in your books-"

"Books can be misleading," said Lockhart delicately.
"You wrote them!" Harry shouted.
"My dear boy," said Lockhart, straightening up and frowning at Harry. "Do use your common sense. My books wouldn't have sold half as well if people didn't think I'd done all *of that,*

http://www.george-macdonald.com/harry_potter_granger.htm

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"So you've just been taking credit for what a load of other people have done?" said Harry incredulously.

"Harry, Harry," said Lockhart, shaking his head impatiently, "it's not nearly as simple as that. There was work involved. I had to track these people down. Ask them exactly how they managed to do what they did. Then I had to put a Memory Charm on them so they wouldn't remember doing it. If there's one thing I pride myself on, it's my Memory Charms. No, it's been a lot of work, Harry. It's not all book signings and publicity photos, you know. You want fame, you have to be prepared for a long, hard slog."

He banged the lids of the trunks shut and locked them.

"Let's see," he said. "I think that's everything. Yes. Only one thing left."

He pulled out his wand and turned to them.

"Awfully sorry, boys, but I'll have to put a Memory Charm on you now. Can't have you blabbing my secrets all over the place. I'd never sell another book -" (*Chamber*, pages 297-298)

Harry and Ron disarm him and force him to join them in their pursuit of the Chamber. He gets Ron's broken wand when they are "miles under the school", though, and causes a cave-in by trying another Memory Charm (the wand explodes). The back firing Memory Charm obviates his memory, which tragedy compels Dumbledore to say later, "Impaled upon your own sword, Gilderoy!" (page 331). Most everyone cheers, professors and students alike, when it is announced at the Leaving Feast that Professor Lockhart "would be unable to return next year, owing to the fact that he needed to go away and get his memory back" (page 340).

In the world of Harry Potter, where the virtues of bravery, selflessness and loyalty are prized above all, you're not supposed to like Gilderoy. We can laugh at him but Rowling clearly doesn't want us thinking of him as a role model. He is a cartoon figure of everything self-important, self-promoting, superficial, effeminate, and emasculating: everything the Harry Potter books hope to overcome and replace with heroic, masculine virtues and 'Stock Responses'.

If we never met him, the name Rowling gives him would tell us we weren't supposed to like him. 'Gilderoy Lockhart' breaks down to 'gilded' (given a deceptively attractive appearance) 'roi' (French for 'king') and 'lock' (shut tight) 'hart' (heart). His name tells us he is a false, 'pretty boy' prince with a closed heart, which is to say a 'hard heart' and 'spiritually dead'. What more could she tell us? Not much.

The fact that his only magic, his 'sword', is the Memory Charm reveals

Rowling's estimation of the value of his books. They are lies, were only written for the promotion of their author, and, one has to guess, not for guys. Their strength is they help you forget; they're an escape wherein you can forget what you are about - and what the author really is about, too.

Rowling hates Gilderoy's kind of fiction; it's everything her fiction is not. In this 'second book within the book', then, she offers this character to her critics as a foil to her own work. Children's literature that does not come from true belief and out of genuine love and concern for readers demeans them and distracts them from spiritual combat readiness.

There are no 'stock responses' in Gilderoy's books, no right alignment of soul, and certainly no baptism of the imagination in Christian doctrines and symbols. ~~Rather than Christ, the true king, all we find in Lockhart's books is himself: Gilderoy, the false king.~~ 3

So who is the real life model for Gilderoy Lockhart? ^{Orvendon's guess} ~~My guess~~ is Philip Pullman, author of *The Dark Materials* trilogy and many other, much... admired children's books. ~~I have a few reasons for guessing Pullman, some good, some silly. Let's start with the 'off the wall' stuff.~~

★ 1) Every person I have met or read that loves his books (including his daughters) is female. ~~Here are a couple of raves from reviews written in the New York Times by women.~~

"War, politics, magic, science, individual lives and cosmic destinies are all here. They are not flung together; they are shaped and assembled into a narrative of tremendous space by a man with a generous, precise intelligence. If you are going to preface your books with passages from Milton, Rilke and John Ashbery, then you had better write well. Pullman does. His prose has texture and flexibility, like excellent fabric. And he gives us so much. Suspense of course, but such degrees of pleasure, excitement (the excitement of meeting characters, not just adventurers) and grief. And such joy - the joy of thinking, of testing your senses and feelings, of knowing your imagination is entering worlds not dreamed of in the usual philosophies" (Margo Jefferson, 'Harry Potter for Grown-Ups', NYT, 20 January, 2002).

★ "One can only hope that where Pullman leads [the children] will follow, and discover the dissenting tradition from which these books spring. This is remarkable writing: courageous and dangerous, as the best art should be. Pullman envisions a world without God, but not without hope" (Erica Wagner, Times of London, quoted NYT, 'The Man who Dared Make Religion the Villain', 6 November 2000).

2) *His Dark Materials* trilogy was 'big news' and Pullman a star at English book fairs when Harry Potter was still just a new title from a small publishing house - and it is at one of those events that Rowling is said to have met her 'Lockhart' model; and

3) One of the lead characters in more than one of Pullman's books is named Sallie Lockhart.

Onto more serious reasons for Rowling to choose Pullman as her 'Man'



1) Pullman feels nothing but disdain for C. S. Lewis and the 'Narnia School' of Children's fiction

"Mr. Pullman's book offers an explicit alternative to C.S. Lewis's *Chronicles of Narnia*, with their pervasive Christian message. In the Narnia books, nestled inside the delightful stories of talking animals, heroic challenges and whimsical scenes, the meaning is clear: the heroes find true happiness only after death, when their spiritual superiority buys them passage to heaven.

"It is a conclusion with which Mr. Pullman thoroughly disagrees. "When you look at what C. S. Lewis is saying, his message is so antilife, so cruel, so unjust," he said. "The view that the Narnia books have for the material world is one of almost undisguised contempt. At one point, the old professor says: 'It's all in Plato' - meaning that the physical world we see around us is the crude, shabby, imperfect, second-rate copy of something much better."

"Instead, Mr. Pullman argues for a "republic of heaven" where people live as fully and richly as they can because there is no life beyond. "I wanted to emphasize the simple physical truth of things, the absolute primacy of the material life, rather than the spiritual or the afterlife," he said" (Sarah Lyall, NYT, 6 Nov 2000).

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"He opposes the tradition of children's literature as Christian allegory, made famous by the Narnia Chronicles of C. S. Lewis. He is a disciple of that sensual visionary William Blake. And by revising (as Blake did) Milton's theology of Paradise lost and regained, he is paying tribute to Milton the poet and political dissident. He thinks it's dangerous to believe that innocence is at its best when untouched by experience. Or that morality is at its purest when untouched by joy" (Margo Jefferson, NYT, 20 Jan 2002)

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2) Pullman is a public atheist and despiser of organized religion

"Shockingly, Mr. Pullman, a 53-year-old former schoolteacher, has created a world in which organized religion - or, at least, what organized religion has become - is the enemy and its agents are the misguided villains... The author grew up in Wales listening to fantastical stories of his maternal grandfather, an Anglican priest bursting with imaginative energy. 'I think he would be shocked by some of the things in [Dark Materials],' said Mr. Pullman, who was raised a Protestant but became an atheist as a teenager" (Lyall, NYT).

"Pullman has made clear in a lovely essay called "the Republic of Heaven" that he is passionately against any religion that puts its vision of the spirit and the afterlife above human life and the natural world, where our moral and spiritual tests as well as our pleasures are found..... And what does he mean by "the Republic of Heaven"? "No kings,

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no bishops, no priests," says one of the rebels. "The Kingdom of Heaven has been known by that name since the Authority first set himself above the rest of the angels. And we want no part of it. This world is different. We intend to be free citizens of the Republic of Heaven" (Jefferson, NYT).

Pullman's fiction is not, as he imagines, of the 'dissenting tradition' of Blake and Milton (!), but imaginative stock straight from the materialist warehouse. He doesn't believe in the fantastic realms he creates, only in the naturalist, 'this-world-ly' atheism and anti-clericalism he promotes beneath its surface.

The brilliance and real dissent in Lewis's Christian anthropology and cosmology is lost on him; one has to assume because he forgot his grandfather's wisdom after having been enchanted by the demons in his school textbooks. To believe that the natural world and joy in this life are diminished by discerning what is eternal and what is fleeting in the natural is never to have experienced the natural world in its depth, breadth, and height.

In contrast with the Pullman/Lockhart genre and Riddle's diary, the third book in *Chamber of Secrets* does not demean or diminish the reader by indoctrinating them with worldly philosophies. The third book Rowling shares with us in *Chamber*, her 'book about books', is *Chamber of Secrets* itself. It ends with an answer for her Christian critics that one would think they would have a hard time rejecting: the best books for children are the ones that model for them a heroic life in battle with the Evil One and dependent on the graces only available in Christ. That 'best book' model is evident in the battle scene at the end of *Chamber*, a Christian morality play for anyone with 'eyes to see'. 9/2

Chamber as Morality Play

Christian morality plays were the first theater in Western Europe. They were almost without exception either portrayals of Bible stories or 'Everyman' allegories of the soul's journey to salvation through thick and thin. Imagine medieval street dramas at public markets and fairs by itinerant players putting on variations of *Pilgrim's Progress* and the Passion Play. The finish to *Chamber of Secrets*, as morality play, is the clearest Christian allegory of salvation history since Lewis's *The Lion, the Witch, and the Wardrobe*. Let's look at it in detail.

Harry, our 'Every Man', enters the Chamber of Secrets to find and rescue Ginny Weasley. He finds her but she is unconscious and Harry cannot revive her. He meets Tom Riddle. He had thought Riddle was a friend and asks for his help in restoring Ginny. No deal.

He learns then that Riddle is anything but his friend; Tom Riddle is the young Lord Voldemort, Satan's 'stand in' in the Harry Potter books, the Dark Lord or Evil One. Far from helping him revive Ginny, Riddle has been the cause of her near death. Harry boldly confesses his loyalty to Albus Dumbledore and his belief that Dumbledore's power is greater than Voldemort's.

The Chamber is filled with Phoenix song at this point, heralding the

Spirit and the protective presence of Christ.

Satan confronts man with the greatness of his sins but Christ battles on Man's side for Man's salvation from his sins. God sends Man the sword of Faith which he 'works' to slay his Christ-weakened enemy. His sins are absolved but the weight of them still mean Man's death. Satan rejoices!

But, wait, the voluntary suffering of Christ heals Man! Man rises from the dead, and, with Christ's help, Man destroys Satan. Man's innocence is restored and he leaves the World for Heaven by means of the Ascension of Christ. Man, risen with Christ, lives with God the Father in joyful thanksgiving.

If I look closely, I can imagine where different types of Christians might disagree with this thumbnail sketch of Everyman's salvation drama in emphasis and specific doctrines. It would be a very odd Christian, indeed, though, who could not understand what the story was about and would not admire the artistry of the allegory. Using only traditional symbols, from the 'Ancient of Days' figure as God the Father to the satanic serpent and Christ-like phoenix (the Resurrection Bird), the drama takes us from the fall to eternal life without a hitch. Nothing philosophical or esoteric here (can you say 'no alchemy'?).

Rowling illustrates here that her books are Christian and in bold opposition to the spiritually dangerous books our children are often given. *Chamber of Secrets* is an example in the genre of an engaging, enlightening, and edifying reading experience for children - and a powerful rebuke and wake-up call to her Christian critics.

What is *Chamber of Secrets* about? Rowling, perhaps in response to the absence of intelligent discussion of Stone's meaning, in her second book clearly reveals to the discerning reader that she is writing Inkling fiction, i.e., stories that will prepare children for Christian spiritual life and combat with evil. Talk about baptizing the imagination with Christian symbols and doctrine!

She also points out to her Christian critics that their real enemies are not her counter-materialist magic but both the dark magic hidden in their children's textbooks and the 'good children's books' written by atheists and the worldly minded. *Chamber of Secrets* is a tour de force operating on at least three levels of meaning simultaneously. ~~I can~~ we can understand, consequently, Rowling's struggle in writing it and agree with her that it is the best single volume of the series.

Why The Potter Books Are So Popular

In conclusion, to understand the meaning and popularity of *Chamber of Secrets*, 'Remember Cedric Diggory!' As with C. S. Lewis's *Narnia* and Tolkien's *Lord of the Rings*, Rowling's Harry Potter books enjoy such remarkable sales and popularity because of:

1) The Need for them: Lewis described the aims of education in modern times as 'irrigating a desert' in contrast to the popular belief that it is 'to cut down jungles' or clear away delusions (see *The Abolition*

of Man , page 24, for the allusion and *The Last Battle* for its illustration in story). The desert that needs water is both spiritual and mental. Soft heads and hard hearts long for truth, beauty, and goodness even though they have been taught to despise or disregard these as subjective or sentimental qualities. Maslow said 'a capacity is a need', our denied or misdirected spiritual capacities have created a nearly irresistible craving and need for Inkling quality reading.

2) A WOW! Story: Whatever the demand for edifying literature, if it isn't engaging and entertaining as story it cannot have the desired effect. Ms. Rowling's detailed, magical world allows and invites head first immersion and suspension of disbelief. Her readers identify with Harry and are rushed to a catharsis in spirit with their hero via the imagination. They absorb, consciously and unconsciously, just sentiments, heroic virtue, and Christian doctrine while loving the adventures in which this moral education is wrapped. Ms. Rowling's affection for the works of Austen and Dickens (and her like talent for 'manners and morals' fiction and believable characters) is evident in every Potter book.

3) The Christian Meaning: The Harry Potter books do not offer a generic 'good over evil' message. Ms. Rowling writes the powerful, spiritual answer in story form to mankind's larger questions in the only language even a post Christian culture can understand: she writes in the symbols and doctrines of the Christian faith. Harry Potter fans enjoy a resurrection experience in every book and are awash in word pictures and images of Christ and souls in pursuit of perfection in Him. Without this specific meaning, Rowling could not have achieved her unprecedented popularity in a culture that only knows of God in these forms.

4) "Past Watchful Dragons": Lewis was aware of how repugnant anything "churchy" is to most people and especially to children. He once explained that his Narnia books were written to sneak 'past the watchful dragons' that guard our hearts against the Christian meaning of life. Harry Potter is so popular precisely because no one has stirred these dragons. Rowling, by means of her cinderella story, the cover of being anti-Christian, our cultural misogyny, and because she too is considered to be writing only harmless children's fantasy, has been able to bypass the much more ferocious and watchful dragons of our day. Her disguise (as 'welfare-mom Wicca-cultist') does the concealment job more effectively than wearing both Frodo's ring and Harry's Invisibility Cloak.

Perhaps the film version of *Chamber of Secrets* will somehow (magically?) expose Ms. Rowling as an Inkling wanna-be. I have to think that revelation unlikely. In absence of that happy change, then, let us hope that her magic, as Lewis hoped, will continue to act as a counterspell to the materialist enchantments of our times - and that Christians will all join her in this edifying labor.

The Hidden Key To Harry Potter by John Granger, Zossima Press, 384 pages, \$18.95. To order, contact: wow@olympus.net Or visit: www.zossima.com (web site should be available around November 1st)